

English
Book Two
For the class XII

You Start Dying Slowly

by

Pablo Neruda

About the Author



Name	Pablo Neruda
Born & died	1904 -1973
Place of birth	Chile
Profession	A renowned Chilean poet, diplomat, and politician
Literary period	Modernism
Achievement	20th century's most influential poets and Nobel Prize in literature 1971

The Poem

Type of work	Prolific influential poet 20 th century
Main Theme(s)	the celebration of a passionate, active life, warning that existence becomes a slow death when one succumbs to monotony, fear, and insecurity

Note: Pablo Neruda did not write *“You Start Dying Slowly.”* The poem is widely misattributed to him. In reality, it was written around 2000 by the Brazilian writer Martha Medeiros, originally titled *“A Morte Devagar”* (“Dying Slowly”).

The confusion arose because the poem’s reflective, life-affirming tone resembles Neruda’s style, and it circulated online years after his death in 1973, leading to the false attribution.

Theme of *“You Start Dying Slowly”* by Pablo Neruda

The poem’s central theme is the danger of living passively and fearfully. Neruda warns that a life ruled by routine, silence, and avoidance of risk is a slow form of death. True living, the poem suggests, requires curiosity, courage, movement, and emotional honesty. Growth comes from change, passion, and breaking habits. By urging readers to act, speak, and choose boldly, the poem celebrates an active, awakened life over mere existence.

Short Question Answers

Q1- Why does the poet emphasize the importance of change, such as wearing different colors or speaking to people you don’t know?

Ans- The poet emphasizes change because it keeps life dynamic and meaningful. Small acts like wearing different colors or speaking to strangers symbolize breaking routine and mental stagnation. Such changes awaken curiosity, expand perspective, and help individuals grow emotionally and intellectually. By stepping outside familiar patterns, a person resists the slow “death” caused by habit and fear. The poet suggests that embracing change, even in simple ways, is essential for staying alive in spirit and fully experiencing life.

Q2- What kind of emotions or experiences does the poet value, based on the line “If you avoid to feel passion and their turbulent emotions”?

Ans- The poet values intense, passionate emotions that make life vivid and authentic. By mentioning “turbulent emotions,” he suggests that joy, pain, love, and struggle are all essential parts of truly living. Avoiding such feelings leads to emotional numbness and inner stagnation. The poet believes that passion, even when uncomfortable, brings depth, self-discovery, and transformation. These strong experiences connect people to life’s reality, helping them grow rather than remain trapped in a safe but lifeless routine.

Q3- What is the significance of breaking routines according to the poet? Explain.

Ans- According to the poet, breaking routines is vital because routine turns life into mechanical existence rather than meaningful living. When people repeat the same habits daily, they stop growing, questioning, and feeling deeply. The poet views routine as a quiet form of decay that slowly makes the spirit dead. By breaking routines, individuals invite change, creativity, and awareness into their lives. This renewal keeps the mind active, the heart engaged, and life rich with purpose and possibility.

Q4- In your own life, how could following the poem’s advice lead to a more fulfilling experience? Give an example.

Ans- Following the poem’s advice could make life more fulfilling by boosting courage and openness to new experiences. For example, instead of avoiding unfamiliar situations, I could choose to speak in public or interact with new people. This would help me overcome fear, build confidence, and gain fresh perspectives. Trying new routines, learning new skills, or expressing honest emotions would make life more meaningful, active, and emotionally rich rather than predictable and dull.

Q5- How does Neruda’s poem serve as both a warning and an encouragement? Which element is stronger, in your view?

Ans- Neruda’s poem works as a warning by showing that fear, silence, and routine can slowly drain life of meaning. At the same time, it encourages readers to choose change, passion, and courage. While the warning highlights the danger of inaction, the encouragement is stronger because the poet repeatedly urges action and hope. The poem leaves readers motivated rather than frightened, inspiring them to live fully, take risks, and embrace life with energy and awareness.

Literary Devices of the Poem:

1. **Metaphor**

“Dying slowly” is a metaphor for living a passive, unfulfilled life. It does not mean physical death but emotional and spiritual stagnation.

2. **Repetition**

The repeated phrase “*You start dying slowly if...*” reinforces the warning and emphasizes how everyday habits can drain life’s meaning.

3. **Imagery**

References to colors, travel, music, and emotions create vivid mental pictures that make the message lively and relatable.

4. **Symbolism**

Routine symbolizes stagnation, while travel, change, and passion symbolize growth and vitality.

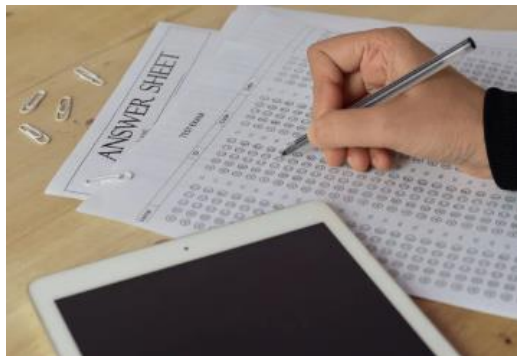
5. **Direct Address (Apostrophe)**

The poet speaks directly to “you,” making the poem personal and thought-provoking.

6. **Tone (Didactic and Motivational)**

The poem teaches and urges readers to reflect, change, and live courageously.

Relevant MCQs



Q1. What does the phrase “*you start dying slowly*” primarily suggest in the poem?

- A) Physical illness
- B) Aging process
- C) Emotional and spiritual stagnation
- D) Sudden death

Q2. According to the poet, what is the main danger of routine?

- A) It saves time
- B) It creates discipline
- C) It limits freedom
- D) It dulls life and growth

Q3. Why does the poet encourage talking to people you don’t know?

- A) To gain popularity
- B) To break monotony and fear
- C) To collect information
- D) To appear confident

Q4. What do “different colors” symbolize in the poem?

- A) Fashion trends
- B) Cultural identity
- C) Change and openness
- D) Social status

Q5. What kind of emotions does the poet value most?

- A) Calm and neutral emotions
- B) Controlled emotions only
- C) Passionate and intense emotions
- D) Emotionless reasoning

Q6. What happens if one avoids passion, according to the poem?

- A) Life becomes peaceful
- B) Life becomes practical
- C) Life loses depth and meaning
- D) Life becomes successful

Q7. Which activity is presented as a sign of truly living?

- A) Remaining silent
- B) Avoiding risks
- C) Traveling and learning
- D) Following routine strictly

Q8. The repeated use of “If you...” mainly serves to:

- A) Tell a story
- B) Create suspense
- C) Emphasize warning and advice
- D) Describe characters

Q9. What tone dominates the poem?

- A) Humorous
- B) Pessimistic
- C) Motivational and reflective
- D) Romantic

Q10. The poem ultimately urges readers to:

- A) Accept fate quietly
- B) Avoid mistakes
- C) Live safely without change
- D) Choose courage, change, and passion

Answer key with justifications

Q1. Correct Answer: C — Emotional and spiritual stagnation

The phrase is metaphorical. It refers to a lifeless existence caused by fear, silence, and routine, not physical death.

Q2. Correct Answer: D — It dulls life and growth

Routine, in the poem, prevents change, curiosity, and personal development, leading to inner decay.

Q3. Correct Answer: B — To break monotony and fear

Speaking to strangers symbolizes courage, openness, and escaping comfort zones.

Q4. Correct Answer: C — Change and openness

“Different colors” represent variety, freshness, and a willingness to experience life differently.

Q5. Correct Answer: C — Passionate and intense emotions

The poet values strong emotions because they make life vivid and meaningful.

Q6. Correct Answer: C — Life loses depth and meaning

Avoiding passion leads to emotional numbness and spiritual emptiness.

Q7. Correct Answer: C — Traveling and learning

These activities symbolize growth, curiosity, and active engagement with life.

Q8. Correct Answer: C — Emphasize warning and advice

The repetition of “If you...” strengthens the poem’s cautionary and motivational message.

Q9. Correct Answer: C — Motivational and reflective

Although it warns against stagnation, the poem mainly inspires change and action.

Q10. Correct Answer: D — Choose courage, change, and passion

The poem’s ultimate message is to live fully by embracing risk, emotion, and transformation

